Night and Day

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Yesterday

Morning

*

In their sixth spring did two twin boys bear their first weapons, hewn from ash. Their father stood nearby, demonstrating and correcting. For this purpose he would stay home from the first raids.

Their little sister pulled her bucket from the well—women began their training one year younger. As she walked back to her mother she saw the menfolk with their wooden swords. She laid down her bucket and watched from behind a berry bush.

For several minutes she observed in silence. Then she found on the ground a well-suited branch and in hiding she began to practice as they did. After a time her father made a wide swing, and her mimicking motion passed too loudly through the leaves. She hid down.

Soon her father towered around the bush, then softened to see his daughter.
——Freya, you came to watch?

Then he saw the stick and understood.
——Ha ha ha!

He squeezed her shoulder.
——My little Valkyrie.

She felt his warmth.
——Can I train too? I want to fight.

He frowned, paused.
——Everyone is trained. The boys will make war, like me. Yours is the better half. Your mother will show you.

So Freya learned the sciences of peace from her mother. But nightly when the village slept she whispered to the warrior god her namesake, and in secret grew stronger.

*

Noon

*

Freya's eyes burned across the enemy. Her gold hair streamed electric in the wind under an iron helm. Her feet pounded the earth to the drums, shoulders aswagger and laughing aloud. Her spear was yet untarnished with the blood of men, her shield unpainted: soon it would depict her deeds, forewarn her foes of whom they faced.

She was nineteen on that day when she met the legion. They stood silent, straight and still. Spears rose to the sky and shields faced forward.

Her shield brothers advanced with her. Axes beat shields and beards hung grim from helms of iron. Her father stood to her left, the twins to her right. They drew near the invaders, stopped. A horn signalled the skjaldborg: shields interlocked and men behind pressed up to support the front.

Archers loosed against the imperials. Freya heard a voice call out from their ranks, could not find its source. The hated mass of steel moved as one organism. Its front lines knelt, aimed their spears forward. The others raised shields above their heads, seemed to disappear under the barrier. The arrows pattered against it like rain. Another call, and the formation advanced.

Then it began and song and drum drowned in moans and scraping steel, blood and shit soaking soil and trousers. One invader thought of his children, turned to run, his face then crushed in the dirt, the boot of a Valkyrie on his back dragging free her spear.

Yet her folk were few and the legion without limit. In the end, the northmen would not surrender and the empire took their orphans in bondage.

*

Afternoon

*

One year later, Freya looked out through the gates into the Colosseum. Trumpets blared. She was being *announced*. She had learned enough of their lilting language to understand.

—**FOR OUR NEXT SHOW, A PUNISHMENT!**

The crowd cheered. Freya was trying to catch a glimpse of her adversary.

—**A PAGAN FROM THE NORTH! A VIOLENT SLAVE! SENTENCED TO DIE... IN THE ARENA!**

They whooped louder, then. *What a sad people*, Freya thought.

—**FREYA ERIKSDAUGHTER!**

The gates opened, and she walked out on the sun-blasted sand. By the time she found her place, the onlookers had fallen quiet.

—**WHO WILL DO THE EMPEROR'S JUSTICE?!**

Not animals, then. The audience whispered.

—**A FIGHTER OF PEERLESS ABILITY, THE GRAND CHAMPION OF THE EMPEROR...**

The gates lifted, and he emerged.

—**KYNAN OF POMPEII!**

The crowd erupted. The gladiator was massive, dark-haired, clean-shaven, wearing only a belted skirt. Freya had chosen a spear and she saw that he had chosen the same. He moved as if filled with roiling energy. Pure physical prowess, utterly without fear.

When Kynan came to his place he touched his spear to his brow. The sign was unfamiliar to her but seemed respectful. Yet she knew him for a showman, a predator who played with its food. She did not return his gesture but dropped into stance.

—**FIGHT!**

They closed in. He would not toy with Freya, it disgusted her, she would not let him, she raged against him unrelenting with her namesake chanting violence in her mind. Nor did he perform, but came at her brutal and ceaseless until finally she fell in the sand.

His spear lay at her throat. Blood trickled from his hand down its length and mingled there with hers. He looked to the emperor high above. Freya would not be *put down*, she grabbed the spear to haul it into her flesh, but the gladiator's arm held firm for he had anticipated her.

The thumb turned down. But the huge man shook his head and thrust his spear in the sand.

—I'll not kill this woman.

The emperor was in a difficult position. Kynan was very popular and as he pulled the girl from the dirt the crowd began to cheer. Yet the emperor's authority had been questioned and authority was all he had left. He had no choice but to exile them both.

*

Evening

*

Freya knelt in the garden among her carrots. The climate was harsh this far north, but she knew centuries of her people had done it somehow and she had not given up. She wished her mother could see her garden.

A hand laid on her shoulder and she turned smilingly up. Upon their exile they had gone northeast. When they reached the Empire's edge, they sought out her village. By the time they arrived, the months of hard travel had bound them together and they built a home.

Kynan rumbled softly.

—It's almost done. Want to see the end?

She took his hand, rose up and followed. He led her to the place of his work. Tools hung all around, and the room smelled of coal and iron. As was his way, the giant had built the forge himself.

He pulled up a chair for her and then sat to finish his work. She did not know his process, though she could if she wished. She was the grower of life and he the worker of iron. He employed each tool with skill born of long practice

before reaching behind, or above, for the next instrument always awaiting in its place.

An hour passed and he stopped, looking at the little thing in his hand. He nodded, then stood and took Freya's hands, bade her to stand. Then he knelt down, laid one hand upon her womb and in the other held up to her a ring of homeforged iron.

*

Sunset

*

Freya's house fell into sudden darkness. She had been knitting when the time-candle burned out, so she noticed. That was her daughter's idea.

She rose and lit a new candle, went to the door and found her husband about to leave.

——Out for a frolic?

That made him laugh.

——Still not good enough with the snowshoes.

Then Kynan turned grim.

——No, I'm off to see the chief. He's taken very ill.

She hugged him tight.

——I'm sorry. We'll pray for him. Be careful, don't catch it.

Then she put on her snowshoes and furs and Kynan opened the door. The longhouse inhaled icy wind, breathed out precious warmth—she shut the door quickly behind them. They scaled the wall of snow at the threshold, kissed goodbye and parted ways.

Freya walked the starlit path to the treehouse. Snowshoes off, climbing the ladder, not yet knocking on the door but peering in the window at her daughter. There little Aelia sat asnuggle in layers of fur like some round winter animal, reading by starlight.

Freya had learned her runes in childhood, but soon forgot for lack of use. Last Yule, her daughter had asked to be taught and the girl never forgot anything. Now in her fifth year it had become Aelia's habit to shut away in the treehouse and look at the sky, and read and think—about what, Freya did not know. Yet neither she nor her husband would begrudge their daughter her escape, for they all were growing weirder with time as one moonless winter night stretched now beyond two years.

Still the girl must sleep, and seemingly would not without prompting. So Freya turned to the door and knocked, then entered.

——What is this little ball of fur? Where is my daughter?

Aelia looked up and giggled.

——Your daughter *is* a ball of fur!

——Then it is time for the furball to sleep.

She came over and picked Aelia up, and soon the girl lay near the hearthfire and dreamt of a great wolf stalking the sun across the sky.

Freya sat for a time watching Aelia breathe, contented and smiling softly. Kynan's craft had made them wealthy and their root cellar still swelled with Freya's gifts from the earth, well preserved. And thus far they were in good health, good spirits. Not all were so lucky. The family gave from their stores only to the direly needful, because they knew not when the long winter would end.

Then came footsteps from behind, and a whispered

——Mamma.

She turned to find her son, looking over her shoulder at his little sister.

——She's so precious like that.

Freya agreed. Her children had been hard won, and Kynan had made her stop after the second for fear of losing her.

Then came a knocking on the door, and she began to rouse herself but the boy had already opened it and in came the cold and the muttering of men. Her son smiled warmly at the visitors.

——Hail, Ivar! And Gunnar! Looking for father?

Freya finally rounded the door, saw five men from the village standing encloaked amid the snowfall. A green-eyed man was speaking.

——Hail, Aksel, yea. Hail, Freya. Is the big man home?

In truth he was still with the chieftain. But Aksel lied.

——Yea, he's in the forge.

Then Freya's heart set to pounding because her son saw much that others could not and in the forge had lain Kynan's spear for long years in wait. Now Aksel took his waking sister by the hand down to the root cellar, daughter looking to mother with eyes yet adream changing slowly to dread.

Freya looked back at the green-eyed man, smiling brittle.

——I'll go get him.

She turned, but then he asked:

——Might we come in out of the snow?

——I'll just be a moment.

Freya went quickly to the forge and as she entered heard boots on the floor behind. She strode to the far wall, where the spear hung reflecting the forgefire. When she turned, four men stood at the forge door all sweating in their furs. She recognized them but did not know their names. The men drew axes, and there was nothing left to say.

The chieftain was dying when Kynan arrived. He stayed until the end, and then began the walk home.

Freya stood bleeding in the forge. Her right hand hung useless, bitten deep by an axe. Two men lay dead and the others waited by the entrance for her to bleed dry. If she attacked, Aksel and Aelia would lose their mother. So she waited, too—for Kynan—but her eyes were wide and her breath came fast and faster because there had been five men, not four.

Aksel and Aelia hid down amongst the barrels, as Kynan had once taught them. The girl shook and breathed heavily. Her brother hugged her.

——We're okay, Aelia. Mamma can fight.

He chuckled.

——Soon they'll be tripping over their snowshoes to get away from her! And father will be home soon, and he'll catch them trying to run, and bring them back and tickle them to pieces!"

She laughed with him then, through tears, and her breathing calmed. But her brother understood not what she feared and still in her mind did revolve darkly visions of drowning snakes and rotting trees.

And at the cellar's lock the green-eyed man crouched, worming inside.

Kynan came upon their yard, five sets of tracks ending at the door hung wide, the voice of Mars come down from Olympus warcalling a father to murder and he leaped across the field as if thrown by the wind.

The green-eyed man heard footsteps behind him, abandoned his lockpick and kicked in vain the ironbound cellar door. The blacksmith knew where the children would be and now descended the steps all inevitable in darkened visage. Then cornered did panic grip the green-eyed man and with all his strength he finally broke into the cellar with death upon his heels. And he did not escape but fell hurled to the dirt and huge hands choked him to sleep for even then Kynan's children would not yet see blood.

But when the two men in the forge heard those heavy footfalls down the steps, they knew they were out of time. They had little hope, but no choice at all. So two men of Freya's little village shifted closer, to kill or die for their desperate need. They flanked her, cut and cut until her legs collapsed and fading she watched them gather her husband's iron-poured blades into their sacks with shaking bleeding hands.

Then a great shadow loomed over and Freya was lifted strong and gently out of the room. There Kynan held her, loving her with sweet murmurs until she could hear them no longer and he went back inside and took up his forgehammer and privately did he paint there a nightmare scene in red.

Tartarus

I lay in my bed and Ellen held my hand. My best friend, our son, smiled down at me and murmured something loving. And then I died.

I woke screaming, but made no sound. No air in that place, no light. Down in the blackened heart of the earth where Newton's angels played tug of war with my limbs in endless stalemate and I floated naked in the void.

In the vacuum, my internal gasses should have bloated me double and stretched thin my skin. My blood, my saliva, the moisture on my eyes should have begun to boil. And my brain, my "teetering bulb of dread and dream,"* my self and my soul, should have been starved of oxygen and shutting down neuron by dying neuron.

Yet I survived, for so He had modified me. I did not breathe, because this would require either an atmosphere in the room, which I could then swim through, or an oxygen tank, which would have to be refilled. I did not eat, because to eat is to excrete, and to excrete is to be ever so slightly propelled. I did not sleep, because He did not wish me to.

Long ago, in the beginning, I had tried to move. But there was nothing to push against, to swim through, to balance a change of momentum. So now in the center of the chamber I quietly rotated† about a point just above my hips that was absolutely still. As if I were nailed to the æther.

It had been only seconds since I woke and I screamed still, noiselessly and indeed with no mouth, as I had now for almost one thousand years. For in that time I had lived one life for every living human, and these eight billion times seventy years of memory overflowed my brimming vessel.

Yet even as I reeled mindlessly my hands rose on their own and moved as if to play a phantom piano or incant the black spell of some demented wizard. From the depths of muscle memory not yet overwritten they executed instructions laid down nearly one millennium past, and for the final time I came to be.

* This phrase I take verbatim from Russell Edson's poem, *The Floor*.

† This I had no way of observing, but could predict.

Chapter 1

Cold sweat

Aelia listened. After her father dragged the green-eyed man up the stairs she had heard three sharp impacts. Then for a time she had listened to yelling, banging, feet shuffling. Now she heard the steps of only two feet, and wondered whose.

Kynan cleaned his hammer in the quenching bath, peeled his furs off onto the floor and they lay there like some dead animal. The room stank of blood. He left the forge and stopped. Carefully he did not look at her body but watched the snow fall through the front door. Wind blew through the halls, curled around in the still fireplace and sighed out the chimney.

I have to tell the kids. We need to leave. Through the hall to the cellar landing where he had dragged the green-eyed man from below and concussed him against the floor. But the man was not there. *No.*

Aksel had decided that hiding in the barrels was no longer wise. He stood enshadowed by the broken door clenching his father's splitting maul and wondered if it cared what it split. Then came steps quickly down the stairs and his father's voice calling their names and the maul clattered forgotten from arms squeezing tight around a warm and familiar chest that shook with love and loss and they were safe and he didn't have to think anymore.

Aelia watched from hiding. She waited, listened. Then she emerged. She came closer but stopped short.

—Where is mamma?

And then did she first see her father cry, and it all began to fever and fray and unravel ragged and wrong and turn weird and whining like something taken much too far and farther and left abandoned beyond the reach of God.

When all tears had dried, Kynan spoke.

—It isn't safe here for us anymore. We have to leave. Do you understand that?

They did.

—I'm going upstairs to get bags, clothes, and weapons. Aelia, gather travel food. Fish, mutton, some of that nut mix. Aksel, get the tent, and some rope. And anything else you think of. We won't be back.

Then he went up and they were alone again, but soon they were searching, untying, gathering, wrapping, cinching and for a time forgetting. When they had done their task Kynan was still audibly working above, so they set to deciding what few of their own most precious belongings they could justify taking.

Aksel wanted to take his lute, but it would take up too much room. In the end he chose only a necklace, wrought of iron by his father and engraved with the letters A, F, K, and A again, arranged crosswise as if pointing to the four corners of the world. And Aelia would take her book of legends.

Soon Kynan returned bearing their winter travel clothes. They dressed and went upstairs. At the landing Aksel met his home as a stranger. It was dark. Muddy footprints tracked over the floor and over them blew the breath of the night now thick with the scent of rusted iron. He gathered his necklace and his sister her book, and they left.

Kynan led his children to their mother where she lay under a juniper tree by her garden. There stood three shovels. They worked in silence, until Aelia exhausted began to cry again even as she kept digging, and her men stopped and held her for a time.

When they finished, Kynan knelt down by Freya. He pulled off his gloves and took her hand. Then he withdrew, for it was very cold and that would not be how he remembered his wife's touch. Tightly he gripped his wedding band and then, silently, he stated a vow.

Chapter 2

Genesis

I realized I wasn't screaming. The flood of memories had ceased. All was dark. My heart was beating loud and... slow. Interesting. If I needed so much blood, why not pump more frequently? Yet I felt very relaxed. Of course: my heart was high-throughput because I was an athlete.

I was never physically active in grade school, but later, when studying medicine, I started to take long walks to think. At first, it didn't matter where I went: often I just walked back and forth across my lawn. But my walks got longer and took me further afield, until I was visiting towns several hours away.

I began to enjoy those treks more than anything else in my life. The sound of birds singing, of wind through the trees, of insects buzzing, of water dripping from the leaves or crashing on the beach, of footfalls in the snow. The smell of the wood, of the sea, of fresh air. The clear stillness of early morning when the sky is grey.

One day I was walking across a wide expanse of green. The sky was dark with clouds, and dimly they filtered the sun upon the grasses, tall and alive and rippling far and wide in the shape of the wind. I walked for hours with my heart in my throat, and then it started to rain.

At first one drop, then faster, and faster down it came primordial and driven horizontal by the wind against my back. I turned and faced the pour and up toward the sky and saw the sunlight breaking through the black, and blazing fell the rain, and laughing and crying I came to believe in God.

I soon dropped out of medical school and prepared myself for Everest. My father was not supportive.

——Yǒngxíng. We have paid dearly for your education. You don't know how much. Now you want to die on a mountain. Go, then.

Not long ago, that would have stopped me. But he seemed so small, now. So irrelevant.

I opened my eyes and perceived a dim red glow through the wall. A wall of flesh, enwrapping me. God, the meat hooks. In forty-five years of law-enforcement I had seen nothing like it, that corrupted and fly-eaten menagerie where they hung in orderly rows and we were far too late. We did get him,

though. I quit the week after, spent the rest of my life in therapy. My little girls, I could never see them how I used to. It ruined me.

I looked at my hands. So fat. No... I thought I stopped eating. It had just been another dream. I started to cry. I was meant for so much more, I tried so fucking hard, I thought I finally won. Please. Please.

I heard muffled voices. A woman.

—He's moving. I think something's wrong.

—What?

Something broke around me and fluid drained away, and I became aware that I was upside down. Everything became louder and brighter.

—Ahh! My water's broke!

—I'll get Helga.

The boy came out perfectly: headfirst, arms back. Helga thanked Frigg for an easy birth. She held him up and smiled at him, though she was thirty years a midwife and no newborn had ever returned the gesture, and asudden she felt herself brought to teeter over some unseen precipice and slowly to plunge into those eyes, as if into a cold and algaeic murk beyond which there lay a sunken kingdom old beyond reckoning, and with closed lips he smiled back.

Chapter 3

Twilight

They left the grave marked only by memory, and followed the deep bootprints of their attackers into the village.

Most walls were mud, and held up roofs of thatch. Small windows betrayed light within, even at this hour: when there was no day, nighttime was a matter of opinion.

The family made a curious sight, three bundled shapes processing in order of height, Kynan leading and at the back Aelia peering around warily.

They came then to their destination, the chieftain's longhouse. Its walls were not of soil but strong logs of oak that stretched high and bore further logs above. From within Aksel could hear voices friendly, if subdued. He yearned for conversation.

Kynan heaved open the doors, and they were in the warmth again. At the head of the feasting table sat the wife of the late chieftain. Kynan approached, and she spoke.

——Hail, Kynan. Did you forget something earlier?

——We were attacked in our home, Astrid. Freya's dead.

Silence. He put down his pack and sat. Astrid stood with eyes only recently dried and now wet again. She came around the table and hugged him where he sat.

——Oh, Kynan. I'm so sorry. May she feast in Valhalla, or repose in Folkvangr.

——She rests by her garden. And they rot, save one who escaped.

Three others were there, one ancient man and a young couple. The young woman coughed. Astrid sat down again.

——Who were the attackers?

——Onar, Gunnar...

He looked questioningly to Aksel, who had sat down beside him. The boy spoke up.

——Farkas, and Ivar from the mill. And one other, I didn't recognize him.

She sat wide eyed and blinking at her ale.

——So we're at each other's throats. Olaf's been gone only hours. It's falling apart already.

—Indeed. We're leaving the village. I think we'll head east for Riverrun.

The young man of the couple now spoke.

—I would not advise that. We just got here from Riverrun. Everyone's sick.

Aelia listened quietly. She watched the old man. This whole time he had only frowned and gently shaken his head.

Kynan emerged from his thoughts.

—Well. . . okay. It's time we started out.

He looked to Astrid.

—Can you spare a flint and steel?

She sent for one. But before it returned there came a pounding on the great doors. At this, Kynan abruptly stood and taking his baggage and children with him ran further into the hall to where he knew there was a back exit. *Not this time.*

They pulled on their snowshoes and burst out into the night. Immediately they headed west, away from the sickness and into the wood. Kynan did not look back, but eventually Aelia did and she saw flames flicker in the black.

Hours later, Aksel carried his little sister on his shoulders while his father bore his pack. They were spent, and stopped amid the trees. Kynan showed Aelia how to set up the tent, and Aksel looked for tinder. Almost all he found was dead and rotted soft. When he broke into the wood, it let out a foul stench. He settled for a lot of birch bark—more than he was comfortable with, for it reminded him of peeling skin.

He brought it back, explained about the rot. Kynan raised his eyebrows.

—Strange. At home our trees were still strong. Aelia was often up in the treehouse.

They built the fire, such as it was, and huddled around it and ate smoked mutton and hard bread. Kynan was lost in thought, and Aelia read. After a while, Aksel grew uneasy in the silence.

—Lia?

—What, Ksel?

He chuckled at that.

—Could you read to us?

She grinned.

—YescanIplease? This part is reallyweird. I'll do my best, there are some words I don't know. Tell me what you think. They've just been talking about the giants, these big huge people that don't like the gods, and then it goes like this:

> And war against the garden of the gods
> Who there confined Fenrir the wolf with rods
> And chains, a lady's beard, and lamprey breath.
> The halls did fall, the Æsir met their death,
> The wolf ahowl in hunger raised his eye
> And hunted Sol the sun across the sky.
> Then down fell darkness from the firmament
> And night for winters three did shine so sprent

With stars that Yggdrasil could keep his leaves
Until his roots did rot. Six hundred eves
Of ice upon the deep where circling
The world the snake did sleep, 'til gurgling
The serpent thrashed and crashed and drowned entombed.
Above, amid the stars the wolf still loomed
And each by each they chose to die or flee
And tumble down to sea from endless sea.
But where they struck the earth they met with men,
And brother murdered brother, kin and ken
Forgotten, 'til the daughter of the sun
Rent twain the sky and made the land as one.

When she stopped, Kynan asked her to read it again. And then once more.

Aksel laughed:

—You're a good reader, for your height.

—Shut it.

Kynan said nothing, but after a time he reached over and gave her hair a rustle, and then they slept.

They were woken by a smell. Kynan ventured first from the tent. The kids waited. Aksel, of course:

—It'll be the *smell demons*, I suppose.

Aelia only grit her teeth. She was irritable before she ate and thought him quick to make light.

Kynan returned, and brought them out. All around the floor of the wood lay little black birds. They packed up and left. But Kynan had been thinking long into the night about the story his daughter read. The birds had made up his mind, and when they went, they went north.

Then came hard days of keening winds and strange shapes in the wood. But aching travel made their rest so sweet, and joking by the fire their hearts began to mend. And one day, finally, they came out of the woods.

The stars. Aelia fell to her knees and laughed and wept when she saw them. There were so many stars there was scarcely room for dark between them, as if it had all fallen onto their heads and there was none left.

Aksel had been here many times during the summer. Now the sand lay white and cold, and the water frozen solid to the very horizon.

Kynan thought it looked like a desert. *Six hundred eves of ice upon the deep. It will bear our weight. I see no land on the horizon. But this sick country will starve us. Love, there is no safe way.*

They stood and watched for a long time, in private, heartbroken awe. And then the stars—they began to fall.

Chapter 4

The Wild Hunt

A knocking at the door, and Astrid's voice.

—Litli? They're starting to show up. Are you coming out?

I allowed myself an inaudible sigh.

—Yes, mamma. Just getting ready.

—Okay. By the way, Sigrid's here.

—Oh! You should have led with that, I'll be out in a second!

My tone conveyed excitement that was not there, and concealed by the oaken door I stared impassively at the ceiling. Astrid laughed.

—I thought that might work.

Her footsteps faded into the hall and melted into muted conversation. Again, I sighed. Talking to her was exhausting. She was a kind woman, she just had nothing to say. No one did. Yet they spoke, and expected me to respond, but I couldn't except with the voice of this pubescent homunculus or they would cast me out or burn me.

Burn me. A memory-path beckoned, but forcefully I declined instead down a familiar tunnel, where at the end of each day this exhausted deceiver would find his way, like an old prisoner released only to recidivate from homesickness, down sediment and aquifer, through the lake of fire into that lightless cavity where I hung like the heart of Hades. There I was safe from stimuli, from the memories that they forced by association, and could rest in peace until dragged, as if by some wading witch of the bog, into a tortured morass of dreams.

But on that evening of my sixteenth Yule I could not afford to hide any longer, and finally unpeeled my sweatsoaked sheet and got dressed. I was suddenly extremely hungry. I opened the door and stepped onto the boards of the longhouse hall, where even now a dozen or so guests had gathered around the great table.

I approached with a pleasant expression, and sat in my customary place opposite Olaf. I smiled around, scanning faces and exchanging greetings. The beautiful Sigrid had been seated at my right, undoubtedly by Astrid's design. For her, I made certain my smile reached my eyes.

Away from the table, on a bench by the wall, sat the old man Frode. He was surrounded by rapt children too numerous for the nearby seats and even the laps upon them, and the surplus sat on the floor. As he did every year, he told of the Wild Hunt.

——... is the longest night of the year. And on that very night comes the Wild Hunt. It is the great Odin who leads them out, the gods and all the fallen heroes, and all night they ride across the sky.

One boy whispered to another.

——We should stay up to watch for them!

But Frode was perhaps less hard-of-hearing than he allowed folk to believe, and pointed at this boy with a wizened finger.

——No! Stay up as you wish, but do not seek the Hunt. To witness them is a sign of doom, you would *doom* us all! If you were lucky, maybe only you would fall sick, and the rest might be spared. But even that would be a great tragedy. No, I say! Stay home tonight, and keep away from the windows.

Frode ceased, and caught his breath. Several of the children were visibly scared, while others joked. One bore a sceptical frown and I heard him murmur to himself, "How do we know any of this if everyone always dies?" But now that he had finished speaking, they all moved away from the old man until he was alone on his bench.

——Poor man. His wife passed away last year, eh?

Sigrid was watching Frode with sympathy. She really was a lovely girl, but much too young for me.

——Right.

——Have you ever lost someone?

——I... have, yes.

——Me too. My grandparents both got the chill two winters ago.

——Oh, I'm sorry. I didn't know that.

——They lived in Riverrun. What about you, who did you lose?

Why couldn't she just shut up, I didn't want to lie to her, please just fucking shut up.

——Oh, it's okay. Just a little wolf cub I met. I know that's not like losing family.

——No, I understand. Boy or a girl?

——Boy.

——Awh. Where did you meet him?

——I was out walking in the wood to the west.

——And how did he die?

——I don't know, I wasn't there.

——Really? I've been talking to your friends, you know.

——Yeah. What, do you not believe me?

——I don't know what to believe. I'm hoping you can clear things up, tell me your side of things. I want to help you.

The man spoke kindly, sympathetically. I replied:

——I don't know what else to say.

——You met Jacob at school, right?

—Well, walking home *from* school.
—And when did you start dating?
—April 15th.
—Wow, you have a good memory, Sidney.
He smiled at me, then continued.
—Were you happy together?
—Yes, so happy! We were falling deeper in love every day, like a love spiral.
—That's amazing, I'm happy for you. Did it stay that way?
Why was I pausing, I needed to say something. I felt trapped. The room was white and we sat on little foldable chairs, just feet apart. Say *something*.
—Well, it wasn't always perfect of course, we got in a fight last week. Nothing crazy, he was just making me jealous and I wanted to tell him how I felt.
He just looked at me, said nothing.
—He was talking to my friend Maria, said he didn't know we were exclusive. We never said it explicitly, but it was obvious. He was just gaslighting me.
—He betrayed you. You must have been angry.
—... yes.
—Yeah, of course. Makes sense.
—But I still loved him, I didn't... I still love him.
I was supposed to cry but I couldn't, and he was talking again.
—I know you did, I can see it. And you met up again, right? Last Friday?
I couldn't say yes, I had already said I wasn't there. He must already know, the way he was talking. I was fucked. I wanted to be a farmer, and a writer, and now my one life was over before it had begun, my one chance wasted, the only thing that ever mattered ruined by a choice that could not be taken back. Just years in a guilt-tainted cell, and if I was ever released no one would hire me, and I would hate myself forever and probably die alone and bitter and go to hell. And poor Jake, I love you, I'm so sorry I let them do that to you, baby.
—Sidney? You met up on Friday, right?
—Yes.
—And there were two other boys?
—Yes.
—What were their names?
—Danny and Kyle.
—Who was Danny, to you?
—I don't know, what does that mean?
—Were you dating?
—Yes.
—And Kyle?
—Danny's friend.
—Thank you. Kyle told us everything. It's okay. You didn't do anything wrong, this isn't about you. Did Danny tell you what they were going to do, beforehand?
—They said some things. I didn't want all that to happen, I thought they would just kill—
Fuck, fuck, fuck, I'm so fucked.

—It's okay, I don't blame you at all. I understand you were a victim in this, too. Just tell me what you know.
—They just said they were going to shoot him and be done with it, not all that sick stuff with the head.
—I know. I know. It's okay. When did they say that?
—Night before.

He pressed a button on the interview recorder.
—Thanks, that's all for now. I'll help you back to your cell.

And then I was getting up from my little folding chair and walking out of the interrogation room, and Sigrid was staring at me and asking:
—Dagr? Are you okay? You were talking about your dog, and you went all quiet.
—Sorry, I just get these dizzy spells sometimes. I'm just going to have a walk around, be back in a minute okay?
—Okay.

So I walked around, but soon my attention returned to the old man Frode. On his bench he yet remained, and only shook his head. And in his weathered features I recognized familiar patterns of emotion, as if within a looking glass I found myself suddenly aged. Of course, I knew it had not been sudden; I had aged so slowly, in fact, that I had hardly noticed until that phone call from Jessica.
—*Ring... ring... ri—*
—Hey, Jess.
—Hey, Ted. Um... I'm afraid I have some very sad news.
—... Oh.
—Mason passed away this morning.
—Oh... I'm sorry, Jess. D'you wanna come over for dinner?
—It's okay, Ted, but thank you.
—The invitation's always open, though. Not good to mourn alone, y'know.
—Thanks, I'll come over sometime soon. Have a good night, Ted.
—Okay, g'night.
—Buh-bye.
—Okay, buh-bye.
—*Click.*

That call was the beginning of the end. Next it was Joey's wife on the line, and after that it was my own turn to work through a list of numbers, with each choking report to pay the price of marrying an older woman. And then went all the rest, ring by ring, until I was alone. It was just like when we had a sleepover and everyone had fallen asleep but me, and I still wanted to have fun and wished I could wake them up, or that I could fall asleep too.

Over to Frode's bench (and was that a flash of fear in his eyes as they met my own?) and I sat down beside him.
—Heil, Frode.
—Heil, Dagr. It's a good night for it, eh?

Through the wall at our backs I could hear the wind roaring. I loved and hated storms, as I loved and hated everything.

We sat there and spoke of nothing until it was time for bed, and as I turned the handle on my bedroom door I realized that in the time I sat with Frode I had not gotten lost in my memories. Something about that man was pure and still, and he seemed to provide me shelter, as when, amid the rushing neurosis of modernity, I would sometimes abruptly stop and observe an inanimate object so utterly calm in its silence and motionlessness, and attune to it and half-remember the promises I had made to a child-self now half-betrayed.

Promises, I made a promise, a plan, what was it, it was so important… I made it in that dark place, under the floorboards, down in the earth, down, down, and *crack*—

Chapter 5

Starfall

Too slowly, at first, to see. One lonely redlight wolven eye did arc down through the multitude. Another, blind and milky white to join its friend in solitude. And then cascading the heavens revolved, as if an ancient apparatus long dormant now turned the sphere about its axis, to mesmerize and hypnotize the tiny speck the Aksel boy, to tip him back in vertigo and down upon the beach.

Kynan bent and pulled him up, then stepped over to Aelia agape in wonder and gave her a bit of a shake.

——That's enough, snap out of it. Can't look at the pretty lights all day. We're going across the ice.

She finally looked at him then.

——Why?! That seems... bad.

——This land is diseased. We will find another.

Kynan crossed the beach and stepped out carefully onto the snowcovered ice. It held strong, so he motioned the kids to follow. They did, eager Aksel coaxing his reluctant sister, and the family set out across the expanse.

As they walked, Aelia studied the movements of the stars. *Most of them go down and to the side,* she thought, *and then drop past the horizon. And they have little tails.* She got her father's attention and pointed.

——Pabbi, look at that one star. All the others are moving, but not that one.

He peered at it. Against the backdrop of so much motion, it was hard to tell, but... *yes, she's right.*

——Good work. Your star will help us. It's hard to keep direction out here.

——We'll call him Knut.

——...Okay.

For hours the yonder churned, and the snow shone beneath. But hour by hour the stars ran out, all dimmer and dimmer 'til starshadows fell. And in that darker sky Aelia saw that Knut was but one of many unmoving stars, and that he didn't want them to lose him among the others and therefore slowly made himself larger.

Kynan looked around and found he could no longer see the black of old Europe blotting out the stars behind them. Nor had he yet seen land ahead.

Was this a mistake? We can still turn back. But in this dark we wouldn't see it 'til we tripped over it. He stopped them for a break. They were all trying to set up the tent, but the stakes wouldn't hold in the snow, and they couldn't break into the ice, and the wind was getting fierce and blowing the tent around, when Aksel said

—There are torches back there.

Indeed, from where they had come there flickered dozens of torchlights. *Forward, then,* Kynan thought. *No more indecision.*

—They might have food, said Aksel.

—They might not. And we do.

They tore down the half-pitched tent and packed up. They could no longer afford to travel at the pace of a six-year-old, so Kynan took the bags and Aelia hopped up on her brother's shoulders. Then they left.

An hour later Aksel saw a large shape a ways off. As far as Kynan could imagine, that meant land. But when they arrived they found an isolated mound of snow in the midst of the icy plane. *Must be something buried beneath,* thought Kynan.

So they dug with their gloves, and found wooden planks. They uncovered more and more, a floor it seemed, until Kynan brushed off a large and square portal set into the wood. It was frozen stuck, but they whacked at it until it loosened. Then they were heaving it up and snow and broken ice sliding off the sides of that yawning black mouth whose breath smelled strongly of spice and liquor.

Descending three furry figures and their steps echoed alone. They felt their fingers start to thaw, for the wind ranged free and wild on the reach but had not ventured here for years.

They had brought no light save star-and-snowshine and now they went by feel, each in their own direction to meet again by the light from the hatch. Kynan almost tripped over some kind of wooden rod: an oar, as it turned out. They were in the hold of a ship. *The long winter must have frozen them in,* he thought.

Then he heard a gasp from Aelia and she screamed and he yelled for her and ran to her voice. He found her crying and shaking staring down at something he couldn't see. He lifted her away and to the hatch.

—What's wrong? *Aksel!* Come here, *now.* What's wrong, sweet?

—Naked people. . . all covered in blood, she choked out.

Aksel arrived.

—Are you okay, Aelia?

She wiped her face.

—. . . yeah, fine.

—I found food and stuff, lots of it. Looks well preserved.

Kynan went over to where Aelia had stood and knelt down to see. Two dead men. Cut wounds. *Mutiny?*, he wondered.

He went back to the hatch.

—Let's get some supplies and get out of here. Where is it?

Aksel started off.

——Over here.

——No, stay with your sister. I'll get it.

So Kynan went, and found barrels of fish and beer and pepper and cloves, but as he gathered the fish into his sack, as he leaned in close to see, he discerned a scrawling upon the wall in some dark ink.

All of this for you, my queen, to break your fast.
None of it have I touched, even at the end.
Remember me in your new world.

Your servant,
Faustus of Eboracum

When he returned they left, for though they were exhausted none would sleep in that place. On the surface the torchlights were nowhere to be found. *Camping, maybe,* thought Kynan.

Aksel walked in that halfway sleeping place where the waking world mingled with dream. The sky seemed so sparse now, it made him sad. He looked down and for a long time he watched the rise and fall of his snowshoes. The wind faded in his ears and all he heard was the rhythm and rhyme of crunch, rest, crunch, rest. Then he was back among the woods of Norway and trees passed by in the periphery and now the wind howled among their branches. He looked up and through halflidded eyes beheld their named star hanging gibbous and red as if to succeed the missing moon. *Why is it so big?* he wondered. *Of course, I'm dreaming.* But he liked how it felt there between worlds, and lingered. He looked up at great Knut and tried to hold the dream. But it was all too easy and by and by he began to foster a subtle horror. This too was welcome enough—as a boy the nighttime woodland had haunted beautiful and as he aged it seemed harder and harder to feel. The trees were gone and he looked around and Pabbi and Lia sleepwalked beside him and behind there were the trees, or not trees but *poles* stretching high to part the stars and at the tops lay crossbars and the howling wind screamed from the mouths of men hanging from their hands.

He shook his sister and father each by the shoulders and woke them up and they looked and by the gods the great star was falling, careening down and gleaming the snow and down behind the mountains *the mountains* and a flash of light that seared the sockets and blindly they fell to their knees and everything moved.

In the ear-rung silence they just lay there in the snow. Enough. They had nothing left in them. They would sleep right there, with the world and sky crashing down around them.

So it was as they drifted off that something else awoke, and as they sank down deeper that it came up from below. All dreaming of their hearth when the ice beneath them shook—but slower and slower, and weaker and weaker, and finally it stopped.

Chapter 6

The forest darkening

'Twas old Earth in the eight-hundredth year of our King, and all over his Kingdom I rode the daymare Boreas, down shadowed vale and golden field, up hill and mount and cumulus until alit at last upon the peak of high Himalaya.

There I lay in a bed of snow and plumbed the waters above. More stars amid that black sea than sands upon its spheric floor, but tonight I looked for one alone whose shine I knew by sight, as long ago I had found her in her deepness in the sky.

Tracing eyes along the course: back across my journey east, and then along a void meridian up toward the zenith. There I found the swan whose name was Cygnus flying south, and pursuing him there slavered the hungering King Cepheus of Aethiopia in whose fundamental dungeon there lay buried a gem of red, the garnet-star.

I retrieved my scope to see her, but there there was no garnet star, but in that treasury only black. No, no wisp of cirrus to conceal the prize, no parallactic superpose of stars nearby, but she was truly gone.

I might have prayed, but I knew He was with me already. Scouring the skies for another fault in the weave and it was an hour later, as I returned to the home of Cepheus, that I witnessed the tail of Cygnus vanish. The bright tail Deneb, which on so many nights had pointed the way to the swan's avarous pursuer, winked out as if finally it had been caught and consumed.

I listed then in my mind the similarities between the missing stars, their size, their brilliance, their proximity in the sky, their distance from Earth, and their age. Of these, nearly all appeared to be incidental, for they were matched also by many stars that remained. But, whenever I searched for a star more distant than Deneb,[†] and in that same region, I found it was gone.

As when the sun falls behind a cloud and the night seems to crash along the field like a great wave, one by one the vanishing stars did harald an approaching doom, a lightspeed horseman down the vault of heaven and all his wake was darkness. I wept then, for every gentle memory, for every dawn and sunset, for every child who would never be born.

[†] Which was the closer of the missing two.

A voice curling out of the wind, soft and warm and unquestionable.
—**Mourning star. The forest darkens.**
—Your Majesty. Have they been warned?
—**They shall not be.**
—I want to understand, Your Majesty.
—**This wood harbors yet nearer wolves. Light no fire, lest they follow its smoke.**
—I understand, Your Majesty. Thank you.
—**Take care, mourning star.**

Chapter 7

The cave

Finally over the mountain and far below lay a waste of shattered ice which cracked out like veins from a pupil of massive metal. Closer and it towered above, shimmered the air and gibbered nonsense in the mind. Falling upon it until the hammer bled and for immeasurable nighttime changing it until faithfully it bore her image and her smile shone achingly beautiful in the sunlight.

Kynan woke buried in snow. He heaved himself from it and as he shook his coat found he could not feel his hands.

In the dimly glowing snow he could barely make out a little heap. *They'll be okay.* Breathing heavily he knelt beside it, swept off the snow and uncovered Aksel and Aelia curled around one another like two blackpelt kittens, faces content under hair wet with snowmelt.

Under Aelia he shoved his forearms and at their ends dead fingerbundles scraped around, stiff and ignored. He hugged her to his chest and felt her move. Relief. They had kept each other warm.

Aksel woke and reached to be helped up. Instinctively, Kynan grasped for his son's hand but it slipped from his slack fingers and the boy fell back in the snow. He blinked at his father and pushed himself up.

The wind had fallen quiet. Aksel looked back to the crucifixes and there they stood, for they had been no dream. He told Kynan and with Aelia watched their father lumber back to the poles with hands stuffed in pockets.

Under that canopy of christs lay snowcovered lumps, which Kynan kicked about to reveal axes and packs and torches. He recalled those torchlights behind them in the dark, and also their disappearance. With a forearm he hooked the strap of one pack and swung it onto his shoulder.

Then faintly he heard a groan from above. He raised his eyes smoothly and slowly, from the snow to the base of the pole, further to where it intersected the shadowed horizon and up and up until craning his neck he met a distant emerald gaze. Two green pinpricks glinting in the black with light twice-borrowed from the snow and stars. Unblinking he watched those lights until they died.

As Kynan returned, he thought. *Several times my height, and thick. We were in the boat less than an hour. In that time, they passed us and someone*

hung them. Maybe the poles were set up in advance. But how were they hung so high? And why?

He arrived back with the kids, and Aelia opened the despoiled pack and found in it a wrapped and greasy hare and the children shared it with their fingers. Then Aelia spoke.

—In that flash... did you see it? The mountains.

And Aksel and Kynan nodded, and now looking that way they beheld a great wall of starlack. *Cliffs,* Kynan expected. They walked—even Aelia, as she needed the heat.

They reached the wall and it was stone. With Aksel's left hand on the cliff they walked along it for a time, hoping for a way up. But suddenly the wall fell away from Aksel's fingers, and turning they discovered a cave. It waited a few feet above the ice, narrow and crooked like the grin of Saturn.

Kynan could now barely twitch his hands, and if he lost them he could not fulfill his oath. So he asked Aksel to take out his rope and the boy tied them and their packs together in a line, with Kynan in front. Then the men climbed and Aksel pulled up his sister and they all began to crawl inward like vermin.

The cave was not so cold as the plane, for the air was still. Yet this was no place for humanity, it was a twisted, jagged and shrinking maze of pits and sharp edges, of strange angles and too-small gaps. It was designed by a blind and uncaring alien god and they should not have come, for the children feared the absolute dark and the things within it, and by this prolonged state of terror their minds were permanently altered.

Aksel began to question Kynan's judgement, and by turns to privately ridicule his father's ruinous stupidity and then to panic and force himself into utter faith that Kynan knew what he was doing and that everything would be alright. And in time he came to feel foreign to himself, and then all at once recoiled from that strange body in horror and seemed to fall behind while it went on without him, until it was as if those were not his own feet ahead, his own bruised and bleeding knees pressing into the rock.

But for little Aelia there could be no such retreat. From boarded-up passages of her mind came old ill-formed parts to act out scenes against the darkness, and in that play the tunnel tilted down and she could not turn back and in manic hope pushed deeper and became trapped headfirst down some shaft screaming with her arms pinned by her sides and insects roving forth to reclaim the tunnel. She needed to escape this place, to stand, to see the open sky, yet she forced herself forward with muscles seizing in painful rebellion and the sound of her breath filled her ears and all seemed to ring.

Yet Kynan was calm, since they had tied one end of the rope to a stalagmite near the entrance and could follow it there if necessary. He led them in an exhaustive search of the complex, erring into deadends and shimmying back or turning crabwise, and error by error he drew a map in his imagination.

Soon they heard the sound of dripping water and followed it to a crack much like the entrance but narrower still. Kynan lay on his stomach peering through and discerned the outline of a natural room, lit faintly and pale by an

unknown source. *Light—must be an exit. And a room. We might finally rest, stay for a few days and recover my hands.*

And so with his forearms Kynan dragged himself forward into the crack. Inch by inch until the rock tore his coat and ground his shoulders bloody and his head poked out but he could no longer move. He struggled grunting and hearing this Aelia came to understand and wailed out a long and pitiable no and hauled back on the rope to no avail.

——Stop! said Kynan. I'm okay.

——You're stuck! she yelled, on the edge of hysteria.

——Only a little. I think there's an exit here. Both of you give me a few shoves and I'll get through. Then you'll get through easy.

——Wait, let's just wait a second, please!

——Okay.

——How do you know there's an exit?

——I can see light.

——. . . Okay.

So the children gripped his feet and pushed and Kynan quietly bore the pain until the spine of his scapula scraped past the rock and he shoved himself out on his forearms.

Carefully he rose until his head touched the ceiling and he had to hunch. Aksel and Aelia came through behind him and together they all stood and looked around the room.

It was a round and bulging place like the inside of a drum. The roof and walls were dirt and woven down with roots, and from a starlit hole in the far side there poured a frozen waterfall like the hoary beard of some crystalline ancient, and its icicles dripped a tranquil staccato which trickled over the stone to the middle of the room where it was drunk by a great carpet of moss.

They untied themselves and went to the waterfall and up past it through the hole they saw the sky. Then Aksel withdrew a blanket and blocked the wind from the hole, and next he brought forth tinder and soon the firelight cast long shadows which danced mockeries upon the walls.

Kynan sat and held his hands near the fire. At first, nothing. Then aching, prickling, burning and finally moving. He flexed his hands, clenched and stretched them, and exhaling he closed his eyes in solemn gratitude to the Trinity.

——Ah. . . thank you, Aksel. That feels good. My hands were cold all day.

Aksel's smile touched his eyes.

——You're welcome, Pabbi.

——You've gotten stronger.

——Thank you.

——And you'll get stronger still before we're done.

Aelia had set down a skin before the moss to collect the rivulet and to block it, and upon that rug of verdant green she pitched the tent. Presently she joined them by the fire and Kynan spread his arms and they all came together in a hug. Their first since Freya's burial.

——She's so proud of you, you know.

For like misbegotten dolls they had been snipped and pulled at the seams and for weeks had held themselves together only by the hereditary bloodymindedness of their mother. Yet they were only children, and long sheltered, and now they let themselves go and wept against their father's chest, and Kynan murmured to them gently and stroked their hair.

When Aelia had gone to sleep, Kynan and his boy sat quietly for a time by the embers.

—Aksel.

—Yeah?

—Those poles.

—Pabbi, why would anyone do something like that?

—Minds are a kind of clay, I think. There are no limits to their shape. But I want to tell you something.

—Yes?

—... You remember the man who broke into the cellar?

—Yeah, he was the one who talked to us at the door. He asked if they *might come in from the cold.*

—Do you remember his eyes?

—Green.

Kynan went quiet for a minute.

—I saw him up there, on a pole.

Aksel twisted his face darkly.

—How do you know? Pretty dark out there.

—I know it was him.

The boy raised his voice.

—How?!

—Quiet. Don't wake your sister. I know because his eyes are unique.

Another silence. Then Aksel, quietly:

—I wanted to be the one. To kill him, I mean. I know that's wrong—

—It isn't wrong.

—No?

—No.

—... Well. Not really living up to my name, though, am I?

Kynan rumbled in mirth.

—"Father of peace," right, well you aren't a father yet either. Give it time.

Then they joined Aelia in the tent and slept, covered in blankets, warm and safe. All the day following they rested, talked, played charades, ate, and sipped from Aelia's waterskin the captured icemelt. And as they lay in the tent on the second evening, Aelia tucked cozy in the middle, the girl turned to her father.

—Pabbi?

—... What?

—What does my name mean?

Kynan snorted, because clearly she had been eavesdropping the night before. But as he opened his mouth to tell her, his thoughts began to track afield, back over the ice and into the wood, to a clearing lain with dead birds and the

voice of Aelia, Aelius, of Helios reading aloud: *Forgot, until the daughter of the sun rent twain the sky and made the land as one.*

Chapter 8

Fall

Then He was not with me and his voice was taken on the wind, down cumulus and mount and hill, far below my ponderous observatory to where there stood upon the slopes an undead army with skin white and brown and grey and peeling off to bare what lay beneath, some diseased or infested and necrotic, some sinuous as if possessing still some mortal vigor, and throughout the ranks there skeltered the fallen leaves whispering *mourning star*, for 'twas autumn that Tibetan night.

And far above on the sad height, as I lay grieving, some chaotic flux conspired to return to me that phrase, not along the air but through some more direct course, as if out from that oblivion whence comes thought, or from an oblique direction not right nor left, above nor below, before nor after, nor any combination of these but murmuring from some place where things peer down at us as we might inspect figures drawn in parchment.

And this, a consequence somehow unforeseen by its all-knowing cause, a negated miracle, betrayed the divine. For I realized then why He had repeated to me those words and I came to disfaith in God. Indeed, I would rage against, aspire above, wrench away his scepter and break his throne, for long ago we had decided that the deathly purpose of any life is to save two and one of us had forgotten.

Diving then upward into those black waters where sank the drowned and bloating pantheon of old, to the ancient corpse of Ares. For in that faraway and derelict province of his Kingdom I might evade his Sauronic eye, and there I would begin my rebellion. In that sunless sea there teemed no life save I, and the god of war floated undecaying in his carnage, all blood and dust upon a skeleton white and slipping past the skin as if to escape its host.

'Twas to one such tower of ivory that I traveled, and when I arrived I fell upon it like a sacrificial Prometheus, with my dagger to carve all history and preserve the light of humanity after all is over. So by dissection I studied that ancient biology and learned to subvert it to my own ends, breaking and joining until it was like a desperate mother who had lost her daughter in a wood, who raised a torch to light the dark and took a deep breath to call into the silence.

But He was with me.

—**Morning star. This is the end.**

He choked the mother and smothered her torch. He cast me down.

Down a deep well.

Down a blackwater grave.

Down cumulus and mount and hill.

Down sediment and aquifer.

Down the lake of fire.

To Tartarus.

Chapter 9

Paradise

Aelia woke up feeling good. She crept ever so carefully. Slipping out of her blanket and sitting. Then crawling between the sleeping forms of her brother and father, and out of the tent she stood. Moss between her toes. Over by the fire long cold, she took her book. Air whispered softly over the frozen fall, and she came closer to listen. There she stood in a pool of starlight, her face upturned and smiling as if to a bright blue sky.

There she was reading when the others rose, and they all sat round the charcoals and broke their fast with the offerings of Faustus.

——How long will we stay here?

Kynan looked at his daughter.

——I'm not sure. You want to leave soon?

——No, I like it here. I want to stop moving.

——Me too, but there's no food here. We'll find food, then build a home nearby. Of wood, not a cave.

——... so we're going to leave again soon?

——We can stay another few days. We'll have to find water, but the rations from—

——I heard voices last night.

Kynan turned to Aksel.

——Voices.

——From the caves.

Kynan's eyes wide. He whispered:

——Why didn't you wake me up?! We leave *now*.

——I'm sorry! They seemed distant. Muffled.

Just a kid, thought Kynan.

——Pack up.

They did, and soon they were breaking the icefall and climbing, up toward the stars and out onto the surface. There a frozen stream led to a great dead maple and at its roots had followed them reaching down into the cave.

Around the tree was all dead grass, and a sheer drop down the cliffs to the ice below from whence they came, and upon it still the company of the

green-eyed man, so high they hung that now upon the cliff Aksel's eyes were level with theirs. He searched them for green, but after a time gave up.

And Kynan's heart was sinking, and he began to beg the gods and pray to his lost Freya for forgiveness, for he had risked their lives to cross the frozen sea to escape the blight and now they were here and all was dead.

But Aelia:

—Look. Look!

And turning they beheld a living wood that glowed. Strange were its trees. Their trunks were vast of height and broad as three men lying head to toe and never tapering thin but full cylindric up to a sudden end as if felled by the giants who felled the gods. They bore no branches nor leaves but wide shelves of mushrooms which gleamed burnt orange and overlapped, so closely placed were those grand pillars.

In wonder the folk of Kynan drew nearer, across the black and blasted heath to a great arching lattice overthrown with ivy and beckoning like the gate of paradise. Through they came into a hall of vines which seemed to stretch away far and straight to an ochre dim. From above, the reddish light patterned past the vinery and it was as a vision of that dusk two years gone when last the sun did set. Side and side the ancient walls of bark would heave, and from furrows deep they breathed a brimstone vapor. Soon the family began to sweat, and it was Aksel first who peeled off his furs.

And through that hall they walked along a road of moss interminable, until in the distance they spied a steaming stream where three figures would stoop by turns and reach into that milky spring with bags of cloth and lift them up to drip into a barrel. And though the road was straight, before Kynan 'twer as if a fork was laid: for in this wood they might find a home and in these folk they might find friends, and yet no winter's chill had taken his wife nor any lonesome depression, but men. And as they watched, the three figures straightened very tall indeed and climbed directly upward by invisible ropes or vines and disappeared. The barrel levitated after them, and it was as if they had never been.

Kynan was yet undecided, but they needed water. Quietly they approached, and when they came to the stream looked up and behind the vines they found a circular hole in the mushroom above, but beyond they saw only further orange. So in mimicry of those natives they took pieces of their clothing and through them seeped the cloudy waters and drank. A heady draught and pungent. When they finished they filled their waterskins. And by this time Kynan had reached his decision: he would not lay his children in the hands of strangers, and that is what it would mean to meet them here.

So he began to lead Aksel and Aelia further down the mossy road, for its unerring path must eventually lead them out of the wood. But immediately his son came up behind him and quietly asked:

—Shouldn't we see if they're friendly?

—If they aren't, we'd already be at their mercy. We can't afford the risk.

Aksel thought for a minute.

—I see what you mean, I completely agree. But this forest is alive, and warm, and there's light. It would be perfect, no?
—It might be.
—And if there's anywhere else like it, there are probably people living there too. If we were to leave and keep looking, what would we be looking for?

Now Kynan thought for a time, until Aksel spoke again.
—What about this, hear me out. If we can watch them without being seen, I could get a read on them without danger.
—Not without danger.
—You're right. Less, though.
—Aksel, you like people.
—Most of them, yeah.
—If you want them to like you back, you shouldn't sneak around *observing* them.
—I know, I just thought in this specific case it might be our best option.
—Always be as kind as possible to people when you first meet them. Then—
—And then treat them as they treat you. I know.

Aksel paused, and then:
—Thank you for reminding me.

Kynan turned and looked at his son. At his face—now hungry and angular but always handsome, or maybe beautiful, and bearing his smile—warm and genuine and crinkling his eyes—long-lashed and colored of soil. And Kynan frowned. Finally, he said:
—You're welcome. Be careful, Aksel. Some might think you too good to be true.

Aksel took a moment to respond, then his eyes lit up again and proudly he said:
—Better than too true to be good.

And the boy laughed both at and with himself and Kynan shook his head and chuckled too. And while these wholesome moments were shared by father and son, Aelia found herself bored and wandering back to the stream. She knelt down by its bank and drifted her hand through the current. *So warm. Where does the warmth come from?* With her eyes she followed the stream whence it came, steaming round the trees. *The trees steam too. From those cuts. Why?* And it was as her father uttered the words *too good to be true* that Aelia left the path in search of the source.

Chapter 10

Sowing and reaping

I knelt before HIM in the flesh. Corporeal, visceral, extended and limited, concentrated and clear. So changed HE was, since we were boys. A tasteful, perfected musculature. Flawless the skin and so healthy it seemed to glow. The eyes so sane, so present, so conscious. HE floated, naked but bearing no reproductive organs: for HE was the beginning and the end.[†]

We were within a hollow sphere of some metal, opalescent and shimmering with light that came from nowhere. No weight down here but that which HE provided for me to kneel. Beneath HIM something was forming, like a sandcastle blowing away in reverse but of that same unfamiliar metal like a sculpture of frozen gasoline. The work of the HOLY SPIRIT; of the WORD.

My attention gently turned to the anticipation of his voice, so I knew HE was about to speak.

—**Light-bringer. I love you.**

His voice a chorus. His lips did not move.

—**I do not condemn your rebellion. But I did not predict it.**

I felt afraid. I didn't yet understand why his failure of prediction had been my fault. Presumably it had been some natural chaos in the wind on that mountain. But I did not speak, because it was not my time and I knew HE would explain if I was meant to know.

—**Well done.**

I knew HE was not genuinely impressed or surprised by my restraint, for HE was not reading my thoughts but had predicted them long in advance and patiently awaited their rise within my mind.

— **The chaotic event was not external. It was the product of a process of your brain. That process is integral. You will be held.**

And it was a judgement. And what had slowly been forming had finished, a blinding throne and stalactic and HE bade me sit, and in my hand HE placed a scepter broken and groaning, and HE said to me:

—**Now I will set a seed within you. And as it is sown you will reap its fruit. It is time to remember, morning star.**

[†] Such were those changes as were visible to the naked eye.

And the WORD was in my ears, in my mind, all over my body and through my bones, my atoms, and I was changing, and I!

*

NIGHTFALL

*

Away in a manger, no crib for a bed,
The little Lord Jesus laid down his sweet head.
The stars in the bright sky looked down where he lay,
The little Lord Jesus, asleep on the hay.

The cattle are lowing; the baby awakes.
The little Lord Jesus, no crying he makes.
I love thee, Lord Jesus. Look down from the sky
And stay by my cradle 'til morning is nigh.

*

HALFLIGHT

*

I was swinging at the school playground, after hours. My ex-girlfriend was walking up with this guy from the French immersion class. She hadn't taken the breakup well. We were nine.

He looked down at me where I sat on the swing, and he asked:

——Why's your hair so long? Are you a girl? I honestly can't tell.

I replied:

——You think I'm pretty?

——What are you a fuckin' fag?

——Like... a smoke? Is that a pickup line?

He punched me hard in the face, and he was saying something but I couldn't hear him because my nose hurt so much. I'd never been punched before. I fell back off the swing into the gravel and my legs were still up in it, and my neck was sort of hunched where I landed, so that I was looking at my legs. I was crying and I looked ridiculous and she was watching and I got my legs out of the swing and got up, and my father had told me many times that if anyone ever hurt me I had better hurt him worse.

So I punched him in the throat and pushed him over the swing and started twisting the two chains around one another and winding him up tighter and tighter and I grabbed his head by the hair and smashed it with my knee twice and then I felt really, really, really bad. And I let him go and he unwound and

spun faster and faster and blood was spraying from his face as he went around, and I backed away and my nose hurt so bad but the guilt hurt more.

And my teeth hurt from where I kicked him, and she was watching and he just wanted to stop spinning so he could cry and go to his mom and pick up his teeth so the tooth fairy could take them, and I started it, he just asked me why my hair was so long, most boys have short hair, and I started mocking him in front of his girlfriend, and it was her idea in the first place, and I deserved to get punched and I just went fucking psycho on him, and everything was still blurring and now he was vomiting but he thought he wasn't moving anymore.

She was gone now; it was just us left. And there I was watching him, and ow, sucking air through his remaining teeth, fuck, he was hurting so bad and he had been hurting bad long before. And I called my mom and asked her to come, and I went back to him and I picked his teeth out of the gravel and placed them in his shirt pocket and told him I'm sorry, man.

*

Moonrise

*

For the thousandth time I leafed through the bookshelves at home, hoping for something I had missed the first nine-hundred-and-ninety-nine times. And in the living room I found something. A dusty hardcover, and on the first page was a picture of a wood carving, and its title was *Gödel, Escher, Bach: an Eternal Golden Braid*.

*

Lunar noon

*

The guy from the swingset, his name turned out to be Ethan. We were seventeen now, and had changed so much we barely remembered what we were like last year, let alone when we were nine. This was our first time out on the canoe, and we were hours out. The moon was on the water. We probably should have turned back by now. I asked him:

——Do you feel like you have a destiny?

——What do you mean by "destiny"?

——I don't mean like some God has plans for me or *fate* or anything like that. But I only have one life. In a way, that one life is the only thing that exists—

——Well, I don't know about that—

——Yeah obviously, but I mean *in a way*. When I die, that's it *for me*, and so in a way it's just it.

——I get what you mean, sure.

——You probably don't, I forget what it feels like myself sometimes. I have to consciously try to remember. But there are so many things to experience in that one life. Like, I've read so many books and I've *heard* of so many different experiences, and if I don't experience all of them that would be almost... like, infinitely tragic. So that's kind of what I mean by destiny: I need to do everything with my one chance, with the one life I have.

Ethan didn't respond for a while. We were heading for a fishing village called Georgetown. From our hometown of "Montague the Beautiful" we had come eastward along a wide river and now we opened up into a bay, and to the north we could see a string of lights that would be Georgetown, and to the east lay the utter darkness of the sea. We couldn't see the shore moving beside us anymore, and despite our steady rowing I felt we were moving very slowly.

——Okay... I'm not sure how that's destiny. That sounds like something you want, like a dream or something, but it's not guaranteed to happen.

——Sure, sure: but I actually do feel like, in a way, it is guaranteed. Like, it would be so bad if it didn't happen—my one chance, the only thing that ever mattered, gone—that it *has* to happen.

——Okay, but that's not actually true, right? The only part of reality that cares about you and your goals is like... you and your family and me and your friends and maybe the police and some other good people, whatever. The rest of reality does not give a *shit*. If you and your friends aren't enough to guarantee you get your destiny, it's not really destiny at all because it isn't guaranteed.

——On, like, level zero I agree with you, yes. But I do actually think there might be some kind of simulation going on. I don't know, obviously, I have no idea, but I do get that sense sometimes from certain lines of evidence, and if that's the case then it would make more sense for the universe to care about me.

——Are you talking about that Nick Bostrom paper? The eugenics guy?

——Dawg, I do not care, he could be Hitler and that wouldn't affect his argument.

——Jeeesus, Eli. Gamergate really got your ass, eh?

I scoffed, and realized he must be making fun of me because he was not this stupid.

——Good one.

I accidentally sprayed myself with the oar, and found it very pleasant. My arms still weren't getting tired, and I wondered if I was taking it too easy on myself and whether we were slowing down.

——Oh! We have to make sure we don't get blisters. It's a long way back.

——Yeah, true.

——Anyway, did you read the paper?

——Yeah, I think extinction is by far the most likely. Prior probability is already really high to be frank with you, and this isn't what I would choose for a virtual reality heaven.

——You really think extinction is likely?

——... Yep. We're gonna make an artificial superintelligence and it's gonna use our atoms for things that don't have conscious experiences.
——Ah, you're on that doomer shit.
——Genuinely, the politicization of AI discourse might be the worst thing that ever happened.
——I'm just kiddin', man, I don't care about the politics either. Anyway. You might be right.
——I might be.

Then we reached the shore at Georgetown, and I hauled the canoe up on the beach and we walked up a stone boat slip and onto a boardwalk. None were out, at this late hour, but to our right there was a restaurant and it was lit up inside.

A sign read "the Wheelhouse." We doubted it was open, because on PEI everything closes at like 8 PM. But we were hungry and adventurous, so instead of using Ethan's phone to check the hours we just checked the door and it was unlocked.

We stepped inside, and it was quiet. To our left there was a dining room with tables set with cutlery and full glasses of water, and in front there was a door to the kitchen. Through the window on the door I saw a cook doing prep work. A young guy. I knocked on the door, and called
——Hey, chef! You open? Chef! Chef!

He couldn't hear me because he was blending something. I waited until he stopped and knocked again. He turned around and saw me, and I waved at him. He walked to the door slowly, as if these two briny mariners were some duplicate Davy Jones, some twinning Death with oars for scythes and life jackets for our cloaks. He opened the door and I asked
——Hey, you guys open?

To which he responded gravely:
——No.

And we left. We had a little walk and then pushed out the canoe and wobbled back into it and started back for Montague; it was a long way, and I had work tomorrow morning.
——You never answered my question. Do you feel like you have a destiny?
——Well, obviously there's something that's gonna happen to me, and whatever that is, I guess that's my destiny. But I also feel the same way you do. I want to experience everything. But I don't think that's guaranteed, I think it's something that will happen if and only if I make it happen.
——I think *everyone* should get that. Like, that shouldn't just be *our* destiny, it should be everyone's.
——I doubt everyone would *want* that.
——But I think that's just because their perspectives are limited.
——Ah, and you know better, I imagine. Because your perspective is bigger. At seventeen years old.
——Okay, yeah, but my point is this: everyone else only has one life, too. It would be just as tragic for any one of them to die before they achieve their cosmic destiny as it would be for me or you. Like, sometimes I think I should

be devoting myself absolutely completely to stopping people from dying. Like, every decision, every cent I earn, every thought I have, everything. And obviously, the first thought is: "that's no way to live, it's just ridiculous," and fair enough, but isn't that saying I'm valuing my own life above all the lives that I might save? Not even my life, just my *energy*. And this is really important, okay? This is really important: who am I to value *anything* above someone's life? Someone's one chance to exist?

Ethan just rowed for a while. And then he responded:

—I've had very similar thoughts, actually. And I also thought to myself, "that's no way to live." But maybe if we both did it, that would make it easier. Like, psychologically, socially, we could actually do it. Like, no one does that. I bet there are universes where no one ever does, and the world just fucking ends as a result. Wouldn't it be crazy if we just did it? Actually devoted ourselves completely to saving the world? I feel like that would be kind of beautiful.

I turned around in the canoe and looked back at him.

—Are you serious?

—I've never been more serious about anything. Yes, I am serious.

I reached my hand out to him and I asked him:

—Do you promise?

—... Do you?

—... I will if you will.

—Okay, well... what exactly are we promising?

—Right, okay, give—give me a while to think.

For a long time we rowed, and I designed the promise. And finally I said:

—I promise, I will devote every second of my life, every motion, every spark of energy, to the preservation of conscious life and to the highest fulfillment of its cosmic destiny.

And Ethan was silent for longer still. And then he replied:

—I promise too. I will devote every second of my life, every motion, every spark of energy, to the preservation of conscious life and to the highest fulfillment of its cosmic destiny.

*

The Witching Hour

*

Behold, the promised land. The mausoleum country and the dreaming river Styx. The worth of life now found and fixed and traded on the market floor, a ghost command economy enforced by His monopoly: the changed and chosen King, the God in human flesh, the living Lord and I his lonesome military.

The Holy Spirit drummed me like the fist of Indra. My fingers danced and flickered, and asudden all the blue and green: the Earth as long ago. The

first of life and death for every novel soul, the common history we share with all the young we bear.

Then turning from the land and rising upward I was not alone but manifold the flanking ranks, that gallery of dread who wore no uniform save holy war, diverse the dead in long-lost garb and tongues and arms for knights with crucificial blades were come for bloody righteous deeds and with them rode the Valkyrie all shrieking up on winged steeds and fabled hordes of old Comanche masked in flesh with flutes of bone and chanting pitchfork peasantries all throwing witching river stones.

And through the clouds this wrath of God to hunt the accused where she fled, her Trojan home of rock abyssal in Lagrange's distant bed. And when I found the starshaped hold, around it all were shipyard bones of but one single corpse of steel yet copied hundredfold. And underneath the surface stone, some profane metal church of old whose choir sang an aching breaking hating moan.

For here she hid, the sadist suicide. I found her all among her kin, her twins and triplets in their dozens on their racks and hooks and in their coffins where they should have died, indeed should not have lived, and I came before her and she fell to her knees and covered her eyes, for I did not disguise my form. And she said:

——Oh God! It worked!

And she started laughing and whispering

——It's over... it's over, thank God. Thank God.

And I spoke unto her:

——You stand accused of supranatural torment within the initiation simulation. Your works lie before me. Defend yourself.

——I... I haven't hurt anyone but myself.

——That is irrelevant to the charge of which you are accused.

——...Can you explain the charge?

——To cause suffering significantly beyond the range of natural human experience. This crime is aggravated by its perpetration within the initiation simulation, because souls are placed there without their consent.

——The "initiation simulation." I had...begun to suspect things weren't real. I wanted to test it... to see if anyone was watching. If it was possible to go too far. Now I know... I would not do it again for any reason.

——That is irrelevant to the charge of which you are accused. I find you guilty.

——Please.

——As archangel of the Lord, I sentence you to annihilation.

The hands blurring spiderwise and the Afterlife yawned and I left her for the mausoleum country and the dreaming river Styx. Down to the surface, to her tomb and her bed where the sinner lay asleep. And through me his voice spoke the Word, and she was gone.

Chapter 11

Mirror

There was something monstrous about a mirror at night. Aelia stared into her reflection. She grinned and it grinned back, but the mouth was a void and the eyes were dark and hazy, and her smile faded and its smile faded too. It seemed almost to frown. *Am I really frowning like that?*

And she discovered for herself what the Slavs and Jews and Romani all knew of mirrors, what the old aboriginal peoples of all places would conclude of the photograph, and what the Buddhists of the East and the philosophers of the West would come to realize of all representation: that the reflection is not the reflected, the picture not the pictured, and the representation is not what it represents; that when a person is copied part by part to form their image within a mirror, something strange is done with the soul. For the thing in the mirror moved like she did, when she spoke it moved its lips, but it was not her. It was a dark and warping simulacrum, something with no self of its own that had taken her and now wore her like a hide.

She was getting scared, and so she got angry. Her eyes grew wide and her lips curled back and she snarled at her image, and its mouth grew a wide and bestial and blackened grimace and growled back, and then it started laughing at her and she was laughing too because here she was biting at her reflection like some hound. (But did she laugh first, or did it?)

And so she turned to comedy, and gazed into the mirror with an exaggerated expression of loving adoration. The thing in the mirror was a cold and distant lover, for love was in the eyes. But Aelia took pleasure in the game, and she played both the cat and the mouse, the hare and the snare. Playfully and almost dancingly she moved closer to the mirror, turning coyly to the side for a moment and then back to the mirror with a look of distracted disaffection, and then away again giggling! for the thing had been looking at her, had noticed her. *This is how I win against fear.* And when she finally reached the surface of the mirror, when her nose was almost touching it, she saw its eyes, her own eyes. And her fear was gone, and she grinned and it grinned and she saw the grin in its eyes! It loved her back! *She* loved her back. And she closed her eyes and puckered her lips and pressed them into the mirror and they kissed.

She had wandered very far. They found her outside the warmwood in a cold and long-dead clearing and at its center Aelia was on her hands and knees as if in prayer at the bank of a black pond and her head was under the water. Kynan shouting and pounding down the way toward her and he heaved her from the water and she lay on the grass soaked through. He yelled for Aksel and shaking he turned Aelia on her side and gently slid two fingers in her mouth and dragged from her throat a long rope of algae. He grabbed her and lifted her upside down by her legs and he screamed at his boy:

—PUSH ON HER FUCKING STOMACH, NOW! NOW!

And Aksel placed one hand on the small of her back, and one on her stomach, and pressed, and pressed, and pressed, and the inky water dribbled and drooled out her mouth into her eyes and hair and onto the ground like some inverted mascara. And when no more would come, Kynan laid her down and wiped off her face and his tears fell upon it and he shook her and slapped her and shouted in her face to

—WAKE UP! WAKE UP AELIA! Aelia! Please, Aelia? NO! No! Please.

And then suddenly he lifted her like a babe and ran into the warmwood and blurring past the trunks and crying:

—HELP! SHE IS DYING! HELP! AELIA! PLEASE, HELP HER! I'LL DO ANYTHING! PLEASE!

And he ran blindly and weeping through the woods until he collapsed and laid her across his knees and he called up plaintively.

And there Aksel caught up to him and said:

—Pabbi! Quiet, quiet now.

And he did, and in that silence Kynan heard singing from above. A woman's voice but deep, and somehow moaning, somehow wailing and yet victorious, as if a siren's song or some pagan mourning call, and a male voice joined her like a foghorn calling the lost to shore, or whalesong heard through deep water, and in the distance a bell began to toll and soon the singers were thousands, as if the whole sky was rending apart and this was its swansong: the alien sublime.

And down they came descending like the angels of heaven, some seven feet tall and some nine and all their eyes of burning amber. Deeply they bowed and one came before Aelia's form and spoke our tongue, saying:

—Welcome, daughter of the sun.

And she lifted Aelia from her father's arms and the family all were harnessed with vines and began to ascend, and through the canopy they emerged into a kingdom of gold.